Mateo Langer

Rap, Culture, and God

Alejandro Nava

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Music Review 1: Kevin's Heart

The first song I chose to review is J. Cole's "Kevin's Heart." To provide some context, J. Cole released the album "KOD" (Kids on Drugs, King Overdosed, and Kill Our Demons), which featured a combination of songs that provided some introspective moments and emotions throughout his life. The seventh song on the album is named "Kevin's Heart." The song is named after the comedian Kevin Hart. On August 3, 2017, it was reported that Kevin cheated on his wife, Eniko Hart. Similarly, the song's main theme is infidelity. Throughout the song, J. Cole is constantly trying to remind himself why he loves his girlfriend. He starts the song by saying, "She my number one I don't need nothing on the side, said that I was done for good and don't want no more lies". These types of reminders are repeated throughout the song. J. Cole uses the song's title as a metaphor for his own internal battles of infidelity. As you listen more to the song you listen to, J. Cole fights with himself internally to stay faithful to this girl even with all these temptations. "Wishing that I could blind myself from view, and only have eyes, and only have eyes for you." From beginning to end, J. Cole is completely vulnerable. He is aware of his actions and the consequences of them, which is why he takes on a tone of regret in his voice. This type of song isn't really seen in the hip-hop/rap industry, where the artist admits his flaws and becomes extremely vulnerable. Especially to the point of allowing his audience to see into his life.

The production of the song perfectly matches the vibe that J. Cole was trying to convey to his audience. He opens the song with a guitar riff that immediately sets the tone of this song. The rift does a couple of things. It isn't too busy in the background, which is perfect for a song that is extremely lyric heavy. It allows Cole to flow while also not taking away from the piercing lyrics. In addition to the guitar, Cole also uses drums. More specifically, the snare. The snare, similar to the guitar, doesn't overpower the song but rather adds to the mellow flow and feel of the song. Something that I noticed while listening to this song was the use of silence. There are these breaks from all instruments when Cole is just rapping. It really allows the audience to feel like Cole is just talking to you. It's almost like he's one of your friends talking to you about his relationship problems. Another unintended meaning I got from the breaks or silence in the song was that it's like he's crying. When you're crying, yes, you make a lot of noise, but then there are moments when you're crying and realize you have to breathe. The silence almost acts like he's taking a break from pouring out his emotions and is just taking a breath.

An added bonus of watching the music video is you are able to see Kevin Hart's amazing acting. J. Cole asked Kevin to star in the music video. During the video, we are shown what appears to be the aftermath of Kevin's cheating scandal, in which he is doing everyday tasks, but everyone looks at him in disgust. These interactions with random people echo the scrutiny that follows artists and celebrities when dealing with such public scandals.

Music Review 2: Poetic Justice

The second song I chose to review is “Poetic Justice” by Kendrick Lamar and Drake. Coming from the critically acclaimed album “good kid, m.A.A.d city” it is the sixth song. The song features both Kendrick and Drake offering storytelling that talks deeply about the complexities of relationships, love, and vulnerability. The song begins with Kendrick talking about this girl. He obviously has feelings for her, stating how he’s written poems in his songs about her. “I mean, I write poems in these songs dedicated to you when You’re in the mood for empathy, there’s blood in my pen Better yet, where your friends and ‘em? I really wanna know you all I really wanna show you off.” The song is able to be perceived multiple ways. Instead of the song being a love song about an actual woman, it's rather a song about the genre of hip-hop with lines by both Kendrick and Drake. “But I can never write my wrongs unless I write ‘em down for real.” Though following the song's name, Poetic Justice, the relationship that is talked about in the song is a mix of both beautiful and tragic. After the chorus repeats it then transitions to Drake. It is speculated that Drake’s verse is about his ex-girlfriend Zineb (Nebby). Unlike with Kendrick's verses, where he’s talking about a girl he already has, the girl Drake is referring to is one he is actively trying to pursue. Drake's verse is more of an introspection piece than Kendrick's reflective approach. Drake is trying to convince this girl of the better life that he can give her if she will just commit to him. Instead of going on vacations and messing around with other guys,.

The production acts as the cherry on top of an already perfect song. Kendrick and his producer, Scoop DeVille, decided to sample Janet Jackson’s “Any Time, Any Place.” The sample is reworked by Scoop so that it is slowed down, cut, pitched down, and looped throughout the song, giving it an extremely dreamy type feel. In addition to the sample, the instruments play an important role in the song, with the bass adding a base foundation that is hypnotic and laid-back. Similarly, the use of drums and the snare is light. It never distracts the listener from the poetic lyrics while also adding a sort of complementary piece to the melody, creating a soft flow to the song. The song is extremely well produced, with the song never feeling crowded. At no point in listening to the track do you feel there is too much going on at once. The instruments complement each other while also leaving room for the sample and lyrics. On top of the production, the way the song is structured is impressive. The breaks in the song allow the listener to fully immerse themselves. To me, the breaks acted like a parallel to a conversation. With the breaks happening in between verses of Kendrick and Drake. It creates a more intimate listening experience and reinforces the theme of the song.

The music video perfectly ties everything together. At the beginning of the video, Kendrick is portrayed singing about this girl. There is a large group of people, but Kendrick and this girl are only focused on each other. The cameras pan from one another, creating a sense of space between them. It makes it seem like they want to be together but are forced to be apart. A shooting occurs, and the large group of people frantically run away, trying to seek shelter. The camera then pans to a phone that is getting called by Drake. After that, the camera cuts to an ambulance and then to Kendrick and the girl lying face down on the ground. At the end, we are able to see Kendrick has 3 bullet holes in his back.

Music Review 3: Hey Jane

The hit single “Hey Jane” is a part of Tyler, The Creator’s sixth album, “CHROMAKOPIA.” Within the album, Tyler explores themes of sexuality, love, and fatherhood. The theme of fatherhood is really talked about heavily within the song “Hey Jane.” The song is extremely unique because Tyler takes on two voices of different perspectives within the song. He also takes an extremely reflective tone throughout the song. The intro line to the song really sets the tone of the song's overarching theme. “Always, always, always wear a condom, Don't' trust-”. The intro is abruptly interrupted, and the song begins. Tyler immediately begins the song by rapping to his supposed girlfriend, Jane. He seems extremely confused by the news of Jane's pregnancy, stating, “Hey Jane, we got the news and I ain't know what to do, I didn't panic, I was comfortin' you, Still in shock, but damn, the late response, is this really true?” This opening bar is how Tyler is approaching Jane. Basically stating to her how he is scared, but at the same time always reassuring her that he will be there. He acknowledges his mistake of getting her pregnant by rapping. “This my fault, the results are justified, I fucked up, I'm stressed out, I'm dead inside, But, hey Jane, who am I to come bitch and complain?” He ultimately ends his perspective and verse by saying, “Maybe that's a blessing in disguise, not a regret, Look Jane, it's your choice at the end of the day, Just know I support either way, no pressure.” Effectively stating that he will support Jane no matter her choice, showing how he values their relationship, even with this life-altering moment. In the second verse, we are introduced to Jane’s perspective. The verse starts similar to Tyler’s, where Jane is extremely shocked and confused: “Hey T, we got the news and I forgot how to breathe, In a panic, you was comfortin' me, Damn, what do we do, what are the odds? Is this really true?” Shortly after we are shown Jane’s true feelings about the pregnancy, where she expresses how she wants to keep the baby. Jane tells Tyler about how she’s 35 and how this may be her only chance to have the child. Her perspective pierces any listener's emotions. She goes on to tell Tyler how she's worried about doing it alone, but rebuttals by saying how she doesn’t need Tyler’s monetary support. She ends the verse by saying how she’s extremely confused, because on one hand she doesn’t want to have to lose the baby but also doesn’t want to lose Tyler as a friend and companion. Jane’s perspective ends by her stating, “T, no matter the decision of the day, I just want us to be cool either way, No pressure.” It’s similar to how Tyler ended his verse and perspective by saying, “No pressure.” Hinting at the fact that even though this is a complicated situation there is a mutual feeling of not wanting to pressure one another and trying to save the bond they have.

The production of the song creates a sort of warm feeling. You are able to hear a melancholy piano loop, which creates an inviting atmosphere to the song. It adds to the tone of “I don’t want to step on your toes.” It also allows Tyler to flow and rhyme to create a conversational tone. The production isn’t crowded and is spacious, which enables Tyler to create a very smooth feel. The bridge to Jane’s perspective really emphasizes the emotions. With heavy breathing just before the second verse, signifying Jane’s shock as she finds out about the pregnancy. Another small detail that can be heard in the background of the song is a sort of metronome-type ticking. To me, it sounded like the turn signal from a car, representing how everyday people go through this scenario. It could be interpreted as they are calling or leaving voice notes to one another from their respective cars. It adds to the overall fact that they might be discussing this very hard thing to deal with on their way to work, showing how the couple is trying to not let it affect their respective lives.

Music Review 4: C.R.E.A.M.

"C.R.E.A.M." or "Cash Rules Everything Around Me" was released by the Wu-Tang Clan as a part of the album "Enter the Wu-Tang (36 Chambers)". Widely considered to be one of the greatest hip-hop songs of all time. Voiced by Method Man, Reakwon, Inspectah Deck, and Buddah Monk, "C.R.E.A.M." is a song that criticizes America's capitalistic mentality and economy. The song's hook, sung by Method Man, very clearly states the tone by stating what the point of the song is. Verse one is sung by Reakwon, where he is talking about his upbringing. "I grew up on the crime side, the New York Times side, Stayin' alive was no jive." He goes on to talk about his hard life and upbringing in the projects of Park Hills. He talks about how to make ends meet he had to sling drugs. He also goes on to mention how he had to do morally questionable things but is struggling to create a better lifestyle for himself. He feels trapped and in a never-ending cycle of crime and drugs. The next verse is sung by Inspectah Deck. Similar to Reakwon's upbringing, Inspectah Deck too struggled with money issues and turned to selling drugs as a way to make ends meet. However, unlike what Reakwon rapped about, Inspectah faced issues with the legal system, stating, "And stay awake to the ways of the world 'cuz shit is deep, A man with a dream with plans to make C.R.E.A.M., Which failed, I went to jail at the age of 15, A young buck sellin' drugs and such who never had much, Tryin' to get a clutch at what I could not." Incarcerations of black families was a major issue in the 90's. It kept this never-ending cycle of a loss of a father or family figure in the household. This ended up affecting the kids growing up. To make ends meet, kids at young ages would turn to selling drugs such as crack and weed to provide for their families. This cycle was used as a way to ensure the people living in the projects were able to move outwards and create a better life for themselves. Inspectah goes on to rap about how he used drugs as an escape from his situation. Towards the end of Inspectah's verse, he references how he was trying to seek purpose in his life and turned towards religion. "But I'm still depressed, and I ask what's it worth? Ready to give up so I seek the Old Earth, Who explained working hard may help you maintain, to learn to overcome the heartaches and pain." The whole song is about how capitalism has a chokehold on America and shines a spotlight on the flaws. It offers a perspective of people in the projects that isn't always seen or heard.

The song sampled the melody and piano from the song "As Long As I've Got You." The lyrics aren't the only thing that makes this song great. The sampled piano is cut and looped throughout the entire song. It gives the song a sort of feeling of being trapped. When listening to it, it's catchy, but it gives you a sense of deja vu, with you getting a feeling deep down inside that you are repeating the same process over and over. This can be seen as a metaphor for less fortunate families being "trapped" in the projects. With the same cycle of incarceration and crime looming over society. Other than the piano and some drums, there isn't too much going on, which allows the artist to really get into their groove of storytelling without being interrupted. It allows for an easy listening experience and really puts you into the state of mind of these people.

Music Review 5: Sing About Me, I'm Dying Of Thirst

The song "Sing About Me, I'm Dying Of Thirst" is regarded as one of Kendrick's best songs. Stemming from the album "good kid, m.A.A.d city" it of course is an incredibly introspective and reflective piece. The song is really two songs combined into one. The first part of the song "Sing About Me" is really about Kendrick Lamar's friend, who was tragically shot and killed in front of him. Kendrick uses the death of his friend to illuminate the tragic acts of violence that stem from gang's. Growing up in Compton Kendrick was no stranger to struggle. He takes a moment to reflect upon his own personal experiences of grief in the first part stating, "But the type of bullet that stuck had went against his will, As blood spilled on your hands, my plans rather vindictive, Everybody's a victim in my eyes." With the history of hip-hop it isn't often that we get an artist who is willing to be so vulnerable. Kendrick isn't singing about how much money he has, drugs, or women, all things that are traditionally linked to this genre. Instead we get a heartfelt song about how his friend doesn't want to be forgotten. His dying friend's last wish is to make a song dedicated to him where he will be remembered forever. Something that will succeed a funeral. Kendrick gave his friend's memory an everlasting impact on American culture. The second part of the song "I'm Dying Of Thirst" is a more spiritual piece. Kendrick is rapping about being spiritually "thirsty". Where the need for jesus and religion is overwhelming. This song and album is Kendrick telling his audience about a turning point in his life. Where money, drugs, and women don't mean nearly as much as religion to him. He is rapping about his journey to find God. "What are we doing? Who are we fooling? Hell is hot, fire is proven, To burn for eternity, return of the student, That never learned how to live righteous but how to shoot it, Tired of running, choirs is hummin'." The thirst is referring to Holy Water, which is a big symbol in the Christian religion. It is seen as water that can cleanse people. Throughout the song Kendrick is pleading for this water to help him get cleansed of his sins, and is done running from the lord and his new passion for religion. "Tired of running, tired of running, Tired of tumbling, tired of running, Tired of tumbling."

The first part of the song has an atmospheric feel to it. It feels like you're in a big room that only you are in. When I thought about how it made me feel, I felt as though I was trapped in a completely white room, no corners or shadows, just white. That's what this production adds. The piano is very mellow, which helps ensure the tone of the song is felt. You also are able to hear thumping in the first song which to me sounded like a heartbeat. It could possibly be an added metaphor for how he is keeping his friends' memories alive through this song. Even though his friend may have passed, through the beat you are able to hear thumping which could resemble a heartbeat. The second part of the song you are able to hear the gospel choir humming, which only further cements the religious theme to the second part. It enables the reader to feel like they are sitting at mass, and can hear the choir humming as the preacher is preaching.